DEPARTMENT OF EMPLOYMENT AND TRAINING
TNPSC GROUP IV – HISTORY, CULTURE, HERITAGE, AND SOCIO-POLITICAL MOVEMENTS OF TAMIL NADU MINDMAP

ARCHEOLOGY DISCOVERIES

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Introduction

✓ **Kumarikkandam and the Origin of the Tamil Race:** Prehistoric Tamil Nadu was located on the submerged Kumari Kandam. It is believed that the first human species in evolution appeared here and the language they spoke was the root language of Tamil.

✓ **Paleolithic tools and sites:** Paleolithic tools used by Paleolithic people in Tamil Nadu are about 1.5 million years old. These are found in places like Atrampakkam, Gudiam and Pallavaram.

✓ **Excavations and Discoveries:** Sir Robert Bruce Foote first discovered Paleolithic tools in Pallavaram in 1863. Archaeological excavations at places like Athirapakkam have yielded evidence of early human habitation.

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"Chronology and Culture of Ancient Tamil Nadu"

Period	Time sequence	Cultural elements
Paleolithic Age	20,00,000 years ago to BCE 8000	Hand axe, cleaver, hunting, food gathering
Mesolithic Age	8000 BCE to 1300 BCE	Micro-stone tools, lack of metal knowledge, domestication of birds and animals, hunting, cultivation, expansion of groups
Neolithic Age	2000 BCE to 1000 BCE	Coexistence of pastoralists and food gatherers, Megalithic funeral rituals
Iron Age	1300 BCE to 500 BCE	Formation of Group leader, use of iron, black-red pottery, expertise in craftsmanship (potters, blacksmiths)
Ancient history and the Sangam period	From 300 BCE to 300 CE	Chola and Pandya kings, warrior worship, development of literature, maritime trade, continuation of Iron Age traditions

Memorial stones

Memorial pillars – a single upright stone; a memorial for the dead (e.g.: Singiripalayam, Vembur)

Dolmen – a ceremonial monument made of stone like a fire table

Cist – a structure of stones on all four sides, with a capstone on top; a burial structure in the ground.

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Archaeological sites of Tamil Nadu



Korkai

An ancient port in Thoothukudi district, an important pearl bathing place during the Sangam period.

Pottery, brick blocks, and clay rings with Tamil Brahmi script were found



Vasava Samudra

On the coast of Kanchipuram district (near Mamallapuram).

Roman amphora, jars confirm trade contact



Anaimalai

Red/black glazed potsherds, roulette, amphorae etc. were found in the



Karur

The Megalithic site located in the Parambikulam-Aliyar project area

Black-red pottery sherds, talismans, stone-tipped knives, etc. were found during the excavation

Reveals information related to Megalithic talismanic rituals (1000 BC–300 AD)

About 70 km from Trichy, it became a major commercial centre.

Tamil Brahmi script, Roman amphora, roulade pot, and Roman coins were found.

Evidence of urban planning such as brick floors and drainage systems were revealed

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Gangaikonda Cholapuram (Ariyalur)

- The second capital of the Cholas – flourished for 250 years.
- Double wall, black stone pillars, palace wall were found.
- Chola-Chinese trade links confirmed by Chinese pottery.

Poluvambatti (Coimbatore)

- 50 colored stones, clay earrings, and conch bracelets were found.
- Clay seals with Moovendar symbols.
- The bow, fish and sacrificial symbols are of archeological significance.

Kannanur (Trichy)

- It was the capital of the Hoysala kings in the 13th century AD.
- During the excavation of the canal area, Chinese pottery, clay beads, and iron nails were found.
- The building and canal areas are dated to AD 13-14th century.

Alaghankulam (Ramanathapuram)

- It is an archaeological site located on the banks of the Vaigai River, near the beach.
- Red pottery with Tamil Brahmi script has been found, > 100 Mediterranean-style rowlatted and amphora pottery has been found.

Pazhayarai (near Kumbakonam)

- The second capital of the Cholas in the Middle Ages.
- Megalithic potsherds, black/red pottery, ceramic, conch and glass bangles were found.
- Clay earrings and kettle spouts were prominently found.

Thiruthangal (Virudhunagar)

- An ancient habitat mentioned in Silapathikaram.
- At a depth of 65 cm in the excavation, Neolithic tools and pottery dating to 1000 BC – 300 AD were found.
- Clay objects engraved with the Srivatsa symbol were found, confirming the Megalithic culture.

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Arikamedu - Historical Importance

Ancient commercial center

Mentioned in the Periplus as the Poduke Emporium

South India's trade relations with the Roman Empire

⛏️ History of Excavation

1941 - G. Jouveau Dubreuil (French Archaeologist)

1945 – Sir Mortimer Wheeler: Urban structures (warehouse, ring well)

1949 – Jean-Marie Cassel: Excavation extended to Sutuki, Kottamedu

1994-95 – Vimala Bagle: Discovery of extensive commercial sources

📦 Major findings

Arredine vessels – Roman influence

Red Tableware – Local Cultural Exchange

Mediterranean pottery - Amphora fragments (wine, olive oil)

Beads & Metalware – Local handicrafts and trade techniques

🌍 Significance of Arikamedu

Evidence of Ancient Global Trade

Highlighting the historical involvement of Tamil Nadu

Poduke Emporium = important point of the Roman trade route

Keezhadi – Evidence of Secondary Urbanization

🏙️ Second Urbanization (6th century BC)

Urban Development in Tamil Nadu

Similar to Ganga Valley Development

🧱🏗️ Construction Technology

1:4:6 ratio bricks – Sangam construction skills

Strong brick walls – Advanced architecture

✍️📜 Literacy

Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions – 580 BC

🪡🧶 Weaving Industry

180 spindles, loom weights, needles, copper tools

Specialization in spinning, twisting, weaving, dyeing

🌾🚜 Agriculture & Animal Husbandry

Animal remains: Chebu, buffalo, goat, nilgai, blackbuck, wild boar, peacock

Well-developed agricultural economy

🌍💰 Trade

4,000+ beads – agate, carnelian, terracotta, glass

Distribution centers: Northwest India, Rome

Arredin Roles – International Trade Certificate

🎲🧸 Games and entertainment

Terracotta Statues (Human/Animal)

Dice, chip games – entertainment features in social life

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Major Excavate

- Porunthal
- Paiyampalli
- Kodumanal

Porunthal– Dindigul District

- Glass beads
  - In red, white, yellow, blue, green colours
  - Aesthetic and commercial use
- Iron tools
  - Swords, sickles, pikes, ploughshares
  - Indicating advanced agricultural practices
- Tamil Brahmi scripts
  - Pottery with inscriptions
  - Pots filled with rice – indicating food habits

Paiyampalli – Vellore District

- Iron Artifacts
  - Paleolithic black and red ware
  - Advances in Metallurgy
- Iron smelting technology
  - The ability of a metal to melt
  - A sign of technical competence
- Dating
  - According to radiocarbon analysis
  - BC 1000 BC

Kodumanal (Erode District)

Tamil-Brahmi Inscriptions – 300+ pottery inscriptions show the development of Tamil literacy.

Carnelian beads and Roman coins – confirm trade relations with Romans.

Textile production – Spindles and fabric remains reveal advanced weaving technology.

Burials – Pits, urns, chamber tombs, etc. indicate the life of several ethnic groups.

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